Wurtland Languanauts

Classroom Policies and Helpful Information

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To: All Parents and Students
From: Mrs. Jones

Hello Students and Parents!

My name is A. Beth Jones, and I will be your 7th grade ELA teacher at Wurtland Middle School this year. I am excited to get to know each and every one of you (Yes! Parents included!)

My passion for teaching comes from a desire to inspire our young people to become self-sufficient learners, eager to take on the world and become responsible and active citizens. When searching for truth in our technological world of instant access and purposeful misinformation, it is important for us to be able to recognize a reputable resource, understand what is being communicated, and compare the information against other reputable resources. We must be responsible for what we read, and learn to clearly determine fact from fiction, opinion from truth, and pointed discussion. We must be able to identify our audience and communicate our ideas to them in a manner that interests them and they understand. Without the ability to effectively communicate our ideas, they become stagnant. Our true path to growth is through interacting with this vast world of knowledge and discovering the rich diversity of culture and landscape our beautiful world holds for us.

It is my goal to inspire this mentality within you/your child during the short time we have together, and to show you all how important the footsteps you leave in this world truly are.

In order to accomplish this, we will be examining several different styles of literature as well as expressing our understanding of information in many different ways. We will focus mostly on reading, writing short responses, as well as professional paragraphs and essays, but will also work with oral and visual presentation. Our class will frequently participate in whole-class discussion where we, as a group, examine information and share our ideas and opinions. We will be working with various study styles, learning good note taking techniques, and learning how to extract quality information from reputable sources in print and online. Note-taking in class could easily mean the difference between struggling to keep up and being successful in this class. PLEASE - Take thorough notes and study any material covered in class for at least 10 minutes each night.

I look forward to working with all of you in order to make this a successful and exciting school year.

Sincerely,
A. Beth Jones

Supplies List – DO NOT PANIC!!!

These items will be used nearly every day, and each student is required to have the following 4 items, keep them safe, and bring them to class **EVERY DAY**. If you are unable to purchase these items, I can show you how to create a tool that will work just as well:

- Agenda (If you have a multiple-course agenda or use an electronic agenda, that will be fine; but you must devise a way to easily access the information for your responsibilities in this course.)
- 2 – Composition Journals (Bell-Ringers, Vocabulary)
- 1 – 1", 3-Ring Binder (This can be a combined course binder, but you must have a section specified for ELA.
- 5 – Dividers/Folders – You will be responsible for keeping your work organized. How you do so is up to you. I am always available to help you get organized if you need new ideas on how to do so more efficiently. However, I do require you designate room in your binder for at least the following five sections:

    1. Tools and Course Information
    2. Current Assignments
    3. Graded Work
    4. Enduring Skills Practice Opportunity (ESPO)
    5. Writing Portfolio In Progress

The following items are supplies we will be using in class. I have a small collection already for students to use to get us started. However, once they are gone, I do not have the means to replace them. If you are able to donate any of the following items, it would be greatly appreciated.

- ☐ college-ruled loose-leaf notebook paper
- ☐ white copy paper
- ☐ index cards
- ☐ composition notebooks
- ☐ #2 wooden pencils
- ☐ mechanical pencils
- ☐ mechanical pencil lead refill
- ☐ erasers
- ☐ ball-point black ink pens
- ☐ multi-colored markers, crayons, or colored pencils
- ☐ glue sticks
- ☐ liquid glue
- ☐ white-board markers (black OR multi-colored)
- ☐ standard ruler
- ☐ multi-colored ball-point ink pens (in addition to black and please NO red)
- ☐ colored highlighters (no more than 2 yellow please)
- ☐ Scissors
- ☐ White-out

ANY AND ALL DONATIONS ARE WELCOME

Additional items that would be appreciated for classroom donation and use:

- Box-Tops for Education
- Hand sanitizer
- Clorox wipes
- Facial tissues (no lotion)
- Paper towels
- Poster board/foam board (blank)
- Electric pencil sharpeners
- Staplers/staples
- Staple removers
- Page protectors
- Single and/or 3-hole punch
- Any minimal-mess art supplies
- Dictionaries
- Thesaurus
- Encyclopedia Sets – any reputable informative source material
- Floor/desk lamps

- Age-appropriate magazines, newspapers, and reading material. (*Older/out-of-date materials are appreciated as well for presentation projects and collages. Ashland branch Boyd Co. Library sells bags for $1 that you fill with books and magazines they have pulled from their shelves. The bags are approximately the size of a reusable shopping bag. Even if you do not plan to donate these materials to the classroom, it is an excellent way to obtain reading materials for your home!)

- Age-appropriate – educational games working with words, critical thinking, social issues, economics, etc (i.e. Scrabble, Settlers of Catan, Mindtrap, Trivial Pursuit, etc. – Please remember these can only be utilized in the classroom if they provide an educational value). Many of these games also come in app form if you have a device available at home. *Be advised, some apps require purchase and/or accounts to play.

- Old smart devices (i.e. old smart phones, Kindles, iPads, etc. – Even tablets and PCs are welcome. By having a tech center in our classroom, we will be able to interact with technology more easily for our lessons. Classroom access removes the need to schedule our class for the computer lab, and provides more hands-on time to work with 21st Century tools. An in-class tech center will allow us to learn and review with engaging virtual tools on a daily basis and opens up a more engaging means of working cooperatively on collaborative projects.

Classroom Rules

- **R**eady to learn:

  I will come to class ready to learn the amazing things my teacher and fellow students have to share with me every day.

- **E**go-free:

  I will leave my ego at home. We are a family inside these walls. Everyone matters.

- **S**afe:

  I will ensure everyone is safe from bullying and other dangers, because all of us are friends and care for one another.

- **P**repared:

  I will make sure I am prepared every day to follow through with "**R**"; books, paper, writing utensil, and any other items necessary will be brought to class with me and not left in my locker or at home.

- **E**ngaged:

  I will engage in classroom conversations to get the best experience and understanding available.

- **C**ommunity-focused:

  I will use what I learn to make a positive difference in our classroom, city, state, national, and global communities.

- **T**each Learning:

  I will teach my classmates and teacher, and allow them to teach me. We will work together to ensure an effective learning environment.

Unfortunately, there are consequences for not following the rules:

1. Verbal Warning
2. Student/Teacher Conference
3. Demerit
4. Contacting Family
5. Referral to Office/Possible ISI

Classroom Expectations and Procedures

- **Work is not "Optional":** All classwork is required to be completed, even if you are unable to attend class. This includes all absences, including personal and school related reasons. If you do not complete assigned work, you will miss out on key information for future assignments.
- **Be on Time:** Class starts at the bell. You should be in your seat ready to participate by the time the bell rings. If you are late beginning your class work, you will miss important information and activities to our lessons, and possibly fall behind. I want you all to be successful in this class!
- **Be Prepared:** Have assignments ready to turn in at the beginning of class on its due date. Have all class materials available when you enter the classroom. You cannot do the work assigned unless you bring all required material to class each day. Leaving to go to your locker takes time away from your learning and uses time you could otherwise be working on assignments to keep from having homework.
- **Engage:** You will get the most from this class if you engage in teacher and student driven discussions, projects, groups, etc. School is a place for you to learn how to be a self-learner and how to interact with others effectively. Use this opportunity to become your best possible self!
- **Use Your Time Wisely:** Pay attention to the teacher and other classmates when they are addressing the class. Listen with a "hearing" ear, not a "responding" ear (listen to absorb what is being said/shared, not internalizing how you will respond to it). Do not be disruptive – If you are finished with work, work quietly on another project or get out your reading book/material. Use the time you are given in class to complete work and prevent having to work on your assignments at home. You will have plenty of time to socialize with your friends at lunch, in the hallways, or outside of school.
- **Be Supportive:** Encourage and help yourself and your classmates. Learn to recognize your strengths and weaknesses, offering help to others and accepting help for yourself. This is a community learning environment. We are all here to learn, so use your classmates as a tool to help you in that journey.

- If you have a problem, I have an open-door policy. Do not hesitate to talk to me about anything.
- Do not leave the classroom without teacher permission **AND** a hall pass.
- Complete silence when there are announcements – This is a matter of respect. Even if you are not interested in the information, someone else may be and someone is trying to share information – be respectful, be quiet.
- Write legibly and proofread EVERYTHING! I will deduct points for work I cannot read/understand.
- The bell does not dismiss class; I do.
- Keep the room clean! We all have to share this space. Clean up your area and any other messes you see in the room. Put away all class materials. Return your chairs/tables before leaving class.

Start of Class Procedures

- You will enter the classroom quietly and check the SmartBoard and Bell-Ringer box for your start of class assignments.
- You will stay in your seat during Bell-Ringer activities. This time will be used to take attendance. If you finish Bell-Ringer activities early; review the "I Can" statement and any other information relating to today's task so you understand the purpose of today's lesson, review your agenda to make sure you are current on all classroom tasks and assignments, review your class notes and assignments from the day before, and only then you may quietly read your book or work on other class homework.
- You will follow any other directives on the board, paying attention to any assignments that are due and the day's listed activities to prepare yourself for the work ahead.
- Homework that is due to be turned in for the day will be turned in before you begin your Bell-Ringer work.
- Everything you hand in MUST be properly labeled (NDP) and go in the properly marked bin for your class period, unless otherwise directed.
- If work has been completed in your journal, journals will be placed on top of the student's desk and opened or marked to the page work has been completed.

Classwork Procedures

- **Missed Assignments:** If any assignments are missed due to absence, there is no reason for you to fall behind in class. To ensure you have every opportunity to succeed, you may assign a classmate or have your legal guardian pick up the day's work packet at the front office after school. Alternatively, I will create a folder with all missed work for you to pick up from me upon your return. All assignments are to be completed, even when absences are excused. You will be given time equal to the days absent to complete any missed work. If you feel you need more time, you must discuss this with me and get my approval or you will be penalized points as with any other late assignment.
- **Labeling Work:** All documents MUST have your name (common name and last initial), date, and class period (this will be referred to as your "NDP" – or name/date/period) clearly listed in the top right corner unless otherwise indicated. I will not hunt down the owner of assignments. I will set unidentified work aside, but it will be your responsibility to claim work if you have not received a grade after turning it in. As well, failing to properly label your work will result in a 1 point reduction of that work's final grade.
- **Location:** Your journals are to be in class with you every day. This will help you keep the majority of your work organized in an easy to find location. Any work that is to be taken up will be placed into the appropriate class period bin at the start of class on the day it is due, unless otherwise specified.

Attention Grabber

Hands Up – Mouths Closed

When I want your attention, I will raise my hand in the air. Once you see my hand raised, or notice other students raising their hands, you will stop talking, stop any task you are on, and raise your own hand. Once the class is quiet, I will continue with instruction. This procedure effectively quiets the class, and directs their attention to me without unnecessarily adding noise or having to address the class verbally.

Hallway Procedures

Whole-class Hallway Use:

- Form a single line, starting with the first chair through to the last chair (unless otherwise directed).
- No talking while lining up, in the hallway, or entering the new area.
- Remain quiet and in line until you are given further instructions.
- Walk! No running.
- Use quiet feet.
- Keep your eyes in front of you and your hands to yourself.

Personal Hallway Use:

- You will receive ONLY five (5) hall passes per nine (9) weeks – use them wisely. You are not automatically entitled to restroom breaks – plan accordingly.
- Hall passes may be used for going to your locker, another classroom, or the restroom.
- Ask permission before leaving the class, and give the teacher one of your remaining hall passes.
- You must spend one (1) hall pass each time you leave the classroom during the class period.
- Go directly to your required destination and return quickly, no socializing.

Conflict Management Procedures

- Take a deep breath.
- Take responsibility for yourself; identify if your words or actions may be the problem.
- Learn to recognize how a situation or conversation may cause conflict ahead of time, and use your critical thinking skills to find a better way to address an issue.
- Follow "The Golden Rule" – Treat and speak to others the way you would like to be treated and spoken to.
- Identify the consequences to the situation if it continues, and decide if it is really worth the conflict.
- Look for a better solution.
- BE RESPECTFUL OF EVERYONE!
- Take it to an adult. If you are unable to resolve a conflict on your own, take it to an adult before the situation gets out of hand and someone gets hurt.

Technology Resources

Here are links to tools we may be using in class this year. I have also included links to webpages to help you understand the importance of digital literacy and citizenship. All of these sites are excellent tools that can be used in many ways throughout your education and professional lives, so feel free to get yourself acquainted with them. For any page that requires an account, please wait until we are able to create accounts in class or have your parent(s)/guardian(s) contact me for instructions.

- **BrainPOP: https://www.brainpop.com/**
- **Common Sense Media: https://www.commonsensemedia.org/**
  This is an excellent resource for information concerning digital citizenship and how to stay safe. There are many articles, games, and other types of media that deal with interacting in the digital world. The site has different areas for different age students. They are also the creator of the Digital Passport app. Their Digital Passport app is available in both iTunes and GooglePlay stores for $2.99, so be sure to ask permission first.
- **Digital Citizenship: http://www.digitalcitizenship.net/**
  This is a web site that gives really good information for you and your parent(s)/guardian(s) concerning how we should conduct ourselves in the digital world. Please take time to visit the page and get a head-start on becoming a responsible digital citizen. The more you understand about how your online behavior affects others, the better equipped you will be to be successful in this new digital world.
- **Edmodo: https://www.edmodo.com/about**
  I am sure many of you will be familiar with FaceBook. Even if you do not have your own account, you will most likely at least understand the concept of this social media site. Edmodo works in a similar fashion, but it is geared toward educators and students. It is a safe environment for us to communicate and build our classroom community. The application can be accessed through computers as well as smart devices/phones using apps. Another great feature with this educationally based social media is your parent(s)/guardian(s) can create accounts and be a part of our community too!
- **Google Earth: https://www.google.com/earth/**
  This is a fascinating tool. Using this application, you can almost literally travel the world without leaving the classroom. I plan to use this tool, and have you use it as well, to produce presentations where we can "travel" around and experience new things.
- **Popplet: http://popplet.com/**
  This is a fun semantic mapping tool. If you are unfamiliar with semantic maps, we will learn all about them this year. The idea is that you are able to link a central idea to its smaller

parts. This tool can be used for brainstorming as well as building presentations. We will also be able to use this tool in groups where several students can work on a project together from different computers.

- **PowToon: https://www.powtoon.com/home/**
  This is another presentation tool where students can animate their ideas in order to convey their message. I have not had a lot of experience with this tool; but I look forward to seeing how the students like it and if it becomes a quick favorite for presentations.
- **Prezi: https://prezi.com**
  This is a zooming presentation tool. There are many fun things you can do with a prezi-tation. I hope you all enjoy working with this tool as much as I have. There are a few limitations to it (no hyperlinks), but the experience of building as well as viewing a prezi-tation can be really fun. Prezi also allows for multiple users to update information and work together to build a single presentation.
- **Skype: https://www.skype.com/en/**
  I am not sure how much experience we will get with Skype, but I am hoping to be able to collaborate with schools from a different location. If we are able to do this, it will be necessary for you to talk with other students from that class. You can also use this tool to work with professionals in the community to conduct interviews for projects we will be working on this year.
- **VoiceThread: http://voicethread.com/**
  This is a another unique presentation tool. You are able to incorporate many different types of media as well as collaborate with other students. Students, teachers, and even people from the community or other countries can leave audio or text comments on your work.
- **Wikispaces: http://www.wikispaces.com/**
  Hopefully, we will be using this site quite a bit in class this year. This site will allow us to work on documents as a group. Each group member will be able to edit and publish their own work independently inside of the group document, to produce a final piece.
- **YouTube: http://www.youtube.com/**
  We will be using several different video sharing sites to view videos related to class material. We will also be using them to share our own videos for a couple of different projects. Though YouTube will likely be our main video site to use, we may also use SchoolTube.com and TeacherTube.com, or other video sharing sites as we discover new material that relates to what we are learning in class.

Please feel free to share with me any other digital tools or webpages you enjoy using in your other classes or daily life, and we will see if we can incorporate them in our lessons.

Future Writing Assignment Style Sheet

Formatting:

- All work may be turned in hand-written OR typed, unless given specific instructions.
- Black, Times New Roman, 12 point font
- 1" margins throughout document – If hand-writing your paper, do not write in the border areas of the page or on the last two lines.
- Double-spaced (DO NOT add additional space between paragraphs) – If hand-writing your paper, skip one line between each written line.
- Indent every paragraph using the tab feature – If hand-writing your paper, use a two-finger indent.
- All pages should be numbered (this **does not** include a cover or title page but **does** include the bibliography or resource page).

Ideas must be developed in complete sentences and structured paragraph form. **ONE SENTENCE IS NOT A PARAGRAPH**. If writing more than one paragraph, you must use the last sentence in each paragraph to transition from one main idea to another.

ABSOLUTELY NO PLAGIARIZING: The use of primary or secondary materials without proper citation in the footnotes, endnotes, and throughout the work, and no bibliography or resource page. Plagiarism is theft of intellectual property, and will result in immediate failure of an assignment and/or more severe consequences.

Papers must be **WRITTEN IN 3RD PERSON** unless specifically instructed. Since the students name is on the paper it is assumed all statements belong to the student unless explicitly attributed to another source. Therefore, the use of "I think", "I will show", etc. is redundant.

Do not address the reader directly in the 2nd person (i.e. "you know").

NEVER USE CONTRACTIONS: i.e. "can't" rather than "cannot", "don't" rather than "do not", etc

PROOFREAD! Students should be careful to write precisely what they mean, since papers will be graded on what is written when the paper is submitted rather than on what the student subsequently explains s/he "really meant".

AVOID THE PASSIVE VOICE: Passive voice exists when the subject of the sentence is not performing the action described in the sentence. Thus, "A warning was sent to the British" – passive voice, Who sent it? – is less informative than, "George Washington warned the British" – active voice. Passive voice is a problem that is fixed easily. Start to identify it and edit it out of your work.

Each **pronoun must refer to a specific noun with which it agrees in person and gender**. Thus, "Washington warned Britain that they must change" is incorrect since "Britain" is a nation and takes a singular rather than a plural pronoun. "Washington warned Britain that it must change" would be correct.

Direct quotes and information directly related to a primary or secondary source should be footnoted or endnoted throughout the work, and the source must be included in a bibliography/resources page. All footnotes, endnotes, and bibliography work must be done in MLA format. Specific instructions on MLA format: Purdue OWL, or http://www.chicagomanualofstyle.org/tools_citationguide.html

Writing Suggestions, Problems, and Issues

1) Keep a **back-up copy** of your work – Save your work in Cloud or on a flashdrive so you always have it available when you are able to work on it or if you forget to bring in a hard copy to turn in.
2) **PROOFREAD, PROOFREAD, PROOFREAD** – You will be penalized for errors.
3) Ask a classmate, friend, guardian, or teacher to read and **CRITICIZE your paper**. Constructive criticism helps you determine where your work is weak, and allows you to grow as a writer. Do not be discouraged by suggestions of how to make your work better.
4) Be careful of the **verb tense** you use – historians prefer the past tense, so academic papers will mostly be written in past tense.
5) Provide the **full name and identification when referring to a person for the first time**: George Washington was the first president of the United States. – Afterdwards, you may refer to them in an abbreviated form.
6) Identify the author or speaker of ALL quotes: i.e. As **presidential candidate Bubba Billows** once explained, "You have to do your best, always."
7) Always avoid **"THIS"** without a reference word: i.e. "This was a problem." – What was a problem?
8) DUDE! Like, **always avoid slang**, eh?
9) Do not use **no double negatives**.
10) **NEVER** use contractions in formal writing: i.e. it's, can't, won't, don't, you'll, etc. Write out the words: i.e. it is, cannot, will not, do not, you will, etc.
11) **Avoid clichés**, like the plague.
12) Eschew obfuscatory morphemes (**avoid jargon** – academic language specific to the topic the common reader will not understand).
13) Do not rely on words such as "very" or "extremely" – they do not provide any concrete value to your statement.
14) Use single quote marks only when quoting within a quotation.
15) Periods (.) and commas (,) always go inside quotation marks. Colons (:) and semicolons (;) always go outside quotation marks.
16) Do not skip a line between paragraphs!
17) Do not spend money on folders for your papers. You do not get any credit for folders. You may still use them if you choose, but it is a personal choice and not a requirement. Stapling your work is sufficient.
18) Avoid "feel/felt" when you mean "think/thought" or "believe/believed", and use these terms sparingly as they are opinion terms and not concrete facts to support an idea.
19) NEVER use "a lot" in an academic writing.
20) History is non-fiction, and history books are NEVER referred to as "novels".
21) Use specific dating in historical writing. Never say "now." Explain when.
22) Never use only first names in historical wiring except for first identification. i.e. "President Washington argued … ", never "George argued …".
23) Subject and verb must always agree.

24) Always avoid foreign terms when an adequate English *quid pro quo* (Latin term meaning "this for that") exists.
25) It behooves the writer to avoid archaic expressions. Use modern terminology and only terms you are familiar with and comfortable with their use and definition.
26) Mixed metaphors are a pain in the neck and should be thrown out the window. Even if a mixed metaphor sings, it should be derailed.
27) Parenthetical words, however, must be enclosed in commas.
28) Do not be redundant. Do not repeat yourself. Do not say what you said before.
29) Proofread to see if you any words out.
30) Remember to finish what you ….
31) Prepositions are not words to end sentences with.
32) Who needs rhetorical sentences?
33) Exaggeration is a billion times worse than understatement.
34) Go around the barn at high noon to avoid colloquialisms.
35) Make sure to PROOFREAD, double check all spelling, DO NOT abbreviate your words, and use words that are actually words – do not make up your own language.

Do not confuse or misuse the following:

It's = it is
Its = possessive
Its' = does not exist in the English language

Affect = verb
Effect = noun (except when used to mean "caused")

Accept = verb
Except = preposition

Number of people, but *amount* of money or gasoline, etc.

Good = as in taste
Well = as in succeed
(Food tastes good but one does well on an exam.)

To = preposition
Too = adverb meaning "also"
Two = number

Their = pronoun, possession
There = adverb, place/location
They're = contraction of "they are"

Which = to introduce a nonrestrictive clause
Witch = someone credited with malignant supernatural powers

Rein = a line fastened to a bit to control an animal
Reign = royal authority

Peace = a state of tranquility or quiet
Piece = a part of a whole

Allowed = to have assigned a share or to have permission
Aloud = where others can hear

Prophet = gifted with spiritual/moral insight
Profit = a valuable return or gain